only check on inimical elements had to be trusted assets behind enemy lines to access vital secrets and future plans.

The Indian spy agency had two objectives in Afghanistan. First, it needed a significant increase in human assets to fill intelligence gaps and widen engagement with pro-India elements to counter the influence of the ISI-backed mujahideen. Second, it needed sources in every powerful group in the mountain country.

Three R&AW officers, codenamed S. Reddy, Ved Asthana and Asthana's junior, Ashfaq Khan, played key roles in running assets inside Afghanistan. These assets were recruited at different stages of the turmoil in the troubled nation, but each had a prolonged lifespan. Besides numerous informers, the R&AW supported and in return received invaluable inputs from three key figures in Afghanistan —Ahmad Shah Massoud, Mirza Murad Rustam and Abdul Jaleel. This was an intelligence coup. But the real challenge arrived with the Taliban attack on Kabul in 1996 when the assets were in disarray. The rise of the Taliban had devastating consequences for the R&AW's effort to gather intelligence to help coalition forces formulate a successful counterinsurgency strategy-

The biggest driver for R&AW involvement in Afghanistan was the history of the extreme hostile region and Pakistan's tried and tested method of using non-state actors against India. It is worth going back in time to fill in the blanks of the spectacular espionage operations the R&AW carried out in Afghanistan.

A significant event long before the arrival of the spies was the demand for a separate Pakhtoonistan. The movement aimed to ere-ate either an autonomous or an independent state for the Pakhtoons, the tribal people who speak Pashto and inhabit the